shown that “mining” landfill sites to extract the metals can be more cost-effective than mining natural mineral deposits. However, e-waste also includes toxic metals, such as cadmium, lead, and mercury. In countries that both generate and import e-waste, landfill scavenging for metals can be polluting. While Europe now has an e-waste reprocessing industry, relatively few efficient schemes exist elsewhere.

There are many new initiatives, but the world is still very far from Connett’s zero waste ideal. A huge challenge remains for individuals and governments: cut consumption and recycle global refuse that is predicted to reach $4\frac{1}{5}$ billion tons (3.8 billion tonnes) a year by 2050